

ASSESSMENT

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8.1 INTRODUCTION

Educators have used the term assessment extensively to measure and assess students' learning progress, academic preparedness, and skill development over the course of their lives. Measurement, tests, examination and evaluation are some of the terminologies used in assessment and evaluation. The idea of 'assessment' conjures up images of grades, progress reports and a sense of dread for everyone from early childhood to adulthood. "Assessment" is often associated with tests, and adjectives like "creative," "intelligent," "gifted", or "slow learner" are associated with it. This kind of tagging starts in preschool, and continues with us till the end of our education. These tags that we received from our educators from the very beginning of our education influence our

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personality, the way we think and how we act in various life situations. But as educators, we often misunderstand the concept of assessment and limit its scope, confining it only to the marking of our learners' performance. However, assessment has a much wider meaning and scope. Let's try to understand assessment through this chapter.

**8.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES**

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- comprehends the need, meaning and characteristics of assessment;
- differentiates between formative, summative, and diagnostic assessments;
- applies suitable assessment methods for different learning situations;
- explains the role of assessment in an education context;
- elaborates upon the assessment cycle; and
- critically evaluates the best practices in India and abroad and draws lessons for self.

8.3 ASSESSMENT: MEANING AND CHARACTERISTICS

Assessment is a fundamental component of the teaching-learning process, serving not only to measure students' academic progress but also to inform instruction and support overall development. In today's educational landscape, there is a growing emphasis on using diverse and meaningful methods of assessment that go beyond traditional tests and examinations. These methods include observational tools, performance tasks, self and peer assessments, and other innovative practices that provide a more comprehensive understanding of each learner's strengths and areas for growth. Analysing children's responses plays a crucial role in shaping effective teaching strategies. By carefully observing and interpreting how children engage with learning activities and express their understanding, educators can tailor their instruction to meet individual needs and promote deeper learning. Such analysis supports a responsive and inclusive classroom environment where every child has the opportunity to thrive. Equally important is the process of documenting and communicating assessment outcomes. Accurate and thoughtful documentation helps track

student progress over time and provides valuable insights to educators, parents, and learners themselves. It also ensures that assessment is not an isolated event but an ongoing part of the educational journey. When it comes to reporting students' performance, approaches such as 360° progress reports, portfolios, and qualitative narratives offer a more holistic view of a child's development. These formats, along with initiatives like PARAKH, emphasize continuous and comprehensive evaluation, focusing not just on academic achievements but also on personal growth, skills, and attitudes. Through such practices, assessment becomes a powerful tool for fostering meaningful learning and nurturing every child's potential.

We are continuously assessing children informally or formally from birth,” How the child is developing, responding and understanding our common instructions?”. As an educator also we often discuss with our peer members, “Did learners comprehend what we were trying to teach?” We planned an activity to teach a topic to the learners at the time of lesson planning but during the execution of the activity you asked yourself “whether learners are taking interest in that planned activity”? “Should I make some changes in the planning to grasp their interest? “As educators, when we are making inferences from these situations, we are trying to determine better classroom transaction strategies, methods, and techniques to help them learn. Two general approaches for assessment can be distinguished from the discussion above: “assessment of learning” and “assessment for learning.”

8.3.1 Assessment of learning

Students are urged to participate more actively in their education and related assessments. Developing self-regulated learners who can leave school equipped and self-assured to continue learning throughout their lives is the ultimate goal of assessment for learning. At the beginning of a unit of study, teachers must ascertain where their students are in their learning. They must then continuously assess their progress by bolstering the feedback they receive from their students. This type of assessment is also called “summative,” which summarises the child's growth during their time in school.

8.3.2 Assessment for learning

Assessment data is utilised to enhance the curriculum and pedagogy in the continuous process of “assessment for learning.” Although it offers details on

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each child's progress, it is not the sole focus of the "assessment of learning." In addition to determining what the children have learned or not, data gathered about their development, knowledge, attitudes, and skills are used to review the curriculum's stated goals, content, and pedagogy of instruction. The term "formative" assessment refers to the ongoing use of data gathered from child assessments to plan new learning activities and experiences that will help the children grow, as well as to change and adapt current content and content delivery methods. "Assessment of learning" is vital, but "assessment for learning" is more beneficial. To better understand and support children's learning and development, we can define "assessment" as "a systematic process of gathering information about children using a variety of methods, recording this information, reflecting upon it, and using it".

The National Educational Policy (NEP) 2020, recommends that the teaching and learning process should focus on regular formative assessment for learning rather than the summative assessment, as that encourages today's 'coaching culture'. As quoted in NEP 2020 *"The aim of assessment in the culture of our schooling system will shift from one that is summative and primarily tests rote memorization skills to one that is more regular and formative, is more competency-based, promotes learning and development for our students, and tests higher-order skills, such as analysis, critical thinking, and conceptual clarity. The primary purpose of assessment will indeed be for learning; it will help the teacher and student, and the entire schooling system, continuously revise teaching-learning processes to optimise learning and development for all students. This will be the underlying principle for assessment at all levels of education"*. (NEP2020, pg17, Para 4.34)

8.3.3 Characteristics of Assessment

The following are the characteristics of a good assessment:

- It is not a one-time or single event but a continuous process: The assessment is not an end in itself rather it results feed in to give feedback to learners and teachers. They together identify areas of weakness and work to strengthen it.
- It must be an open process: Open assessment, often known as authentic assessment, involves learners and other stakeholders – parents, and teachers. Active participation from everyone is expected, ensuring inclusivity and transparency. It could be accomplished by using real-

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world tasks and projects, requiring students to apply their knowledge and skills. For example, an open book test, wherein learner can be anywhere either in library or home with digital devices during the time of test. Such tests are not confined to the four walls of the examination hall.

- It must promote valid inferences: Assessment must clearly reflect what it is intended to measure so that reliable and meaningful conclusions can be drawn. For instance, if an assessment is planned for identifying mathematical skills of a learner, then it should not be testing the reading comprehension so that the conclusions drawn from the assessment accurately reflect the reality of student learning and can be used to inform meaningful decisions.
- It should always employ multiple ways as measures of performance: The different ways of assessment should be used for finding out authentic assessment. For instance, a paper pencil test, observations, hands on exercises etc to measure performance of a learner in science.
- It should measure what is worth learning, not just what is easy to measure: After teaching a lesson on water cycle, a teacher intends to assess her students. She uses a worksheet with filling the blanks, matching of pairs, labelling the water cycle diagram. This kind of worksheet is easy to design, conduct in the classroom and mark it. But it would not give her an understanding about children's conceptual knowledge. She should give them a few laboratories based tasks, or hands on activities or role play or storytelling. These would be harder to organise but the results of such tasks would provide her the information on what she intended to measure.

Educational standards and values always serve as the foundation for educational assessment. Assessment is a means to achieve and enhance educational goals. These goals = including values and standards- should be made clear to all stakeholders from the outset. The desired learning competencies (skills, knowledge, values, and ways of thinking and learning) dictate what we choose to assess. The educational values and standards should also define how we assess, and assessment systems should guide educators in assisting students in achieving the educational goals, values, and standards.

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**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 8.1**

1. What is the primary purpose of assessment in education?
 - a) to segregate high achiever and underachiever students
 - b) to support and improve learning outcomes
 - c) to promote memorization
 - d) to prepare students for competition only
2. Which one of the following is not the purpose of assessment?
 - a) to identify learning gaps for students
 - b) to assign marks to students
 - c) to alter or refine pedagogies as per requirements of students\
 - d) to identify learning needs of students
3. Pinky a primary teacher at KVS, after a unit test, redesigns her pedagogy of instructions and plan new learning activities to meet needs of students. What does her action suggest about assessment?
 - a) Assessment of learning
 - b) Assessment in learning
 - c.) Assessment as learning
 - d) Assessment for learning

Answer: 1 - b; 2 - b; 3 - d)

8.4 UNDERSTANDING THE ROLE OF ASSESSMENT IN EDUCATION

In every classroom, assessment functions like a heartbeat—it continuously pulses through the instructional process, driving and guiding teaching and learning. While often mistaken as an endpoint to learning, assessment is in fact a formative force: it shapes what, how, and even why we teach. More importantly, it allows educators to understand each learner as a whole—intellectually, socially, and emotionally.

Historically, assessment was seen primarily as a summative act: to test,

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rank, and sort. However, educational shifts towards holistic development, competency frameworks, and inclusive pedagogy have redefined the role of assessment. Today's classrooms are diverse, filled with learners who differ in pace, background, language, and cognitive styles. Teachers must, therefore, design assessments that respect and respond to this diversity.

India's National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 emphasizes formative, adaptive, and child-centric assessment. It discourages rote memorization and promotes understanding, creativity, and real-life application. As per NEP, students should be assessed not only for content mastery but also for problem-solving ability, critical thinking, emotional intelligence, and collaboration.

This paper aligns with these educational ideals by offering teachers practical, flexible, and creative ways to assess learning—and to interpret children's responses as meaningful data for refining pedagogy.

Understanding the different types of assessment is fundamental to quality teaching. Assessment is not a one-size-fits-all concept; it must be tailored to the purpose of instruction, the needs of learners, and the context of the classroom. Each type of assessment offers distinct insights into a learner's journey. The better educators understand the intent and function of each type, the more effectively they can guide student learning. In this section, we explore four primary types: Formative, Summative, Diagnostic, and Ipsative. These assessment methods are not mutually exclusive; when applied together, they create a comprehensive and inclusive evaluation system.

8.4.1 Formative Assessment: Guiding Learning in Real Time

Formative assessment is often referred to as *“assessment for learning”* rather than *“assessment of learning.”* It is an ongoing process embedded in daily instruction, designed to provide immediate feedback to both teachers and students. The key goal is to monitor progress and make timely instructional adjustments. These assessments are usually informal, low-stakes, and non-graded.

What makes formative assessment powerful is its flexibility and responsiveness. Teachers can adapt on the spot based on students' reactions, engagement, or misconceptions. It helps prevent learning gaps from widening by addressing issues as they arise.

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Examples of Formative Assessment:

Exit Slips: At the end of a lesson, students write one thing they learned and one question they still have.

Observation During Group Work: Teachers watch how students collaborate and solve problems together.

Open-Ended Questions: Encouraging students to explain concepts in their own words.

Quick Concept-Check Games: Tools like flashcards, Kahoot quizzes, or Think-Pair-Share activities.

Real-Life Application:

In a Grade 4 classroom in Kerala, a science teacher used whiteboards for instant concept checks. After discussing an activity on shadows, she asked students to draw the shadows in different situations (Morning, evening, noon). She instantly saw who misunderstood the concept and addressed it immediately—before it became a lasting misconception.

8.4.2 Summative Assessment: Measuring What Has Been Learned

Summative assessment is conducted at the end of an instructional period—such as a unit, term, or course—and is designed to evaluate cumulative learning. It is often used for assigning grades, certifying achievement, and reporting to parents or educational boards. Because it assesses learning outcomes, it is typically formal, structured, and high-stakes.

While summative assessment provides an overview of achievement, it does not always offer insights into how the learning occurred or what needs improvement unless it is followed by reflection.

Examples of Summative Assessment:

Unit Tests and Term Exams: Covering specific topics or cumulative curriculum content.

Final Projects: Demonstrating integrated understanding through presentations, models, or research.

Portfolios: Collections of student work that show learning over time.

Important Consideration:

Summative assessments should be aligned with the learning objectives and varied to include different learning styles. For example, offering students a choice between writing an essay or creating a video presentation allows them to demonstrate understanding in diverse formats.

Classroom Snapshot:

At a private school in Delhi, students in Class 5 were given the option to showcase their understanding of a poem through a written paper, a dramatic monologue, or an illustrated description. This approach led to higher engagement and authentic expressions of learning.

8.4.3 Diagnostic Assessment: Knowing Before Teaching

Diagnostic assessment is often the first step before formal instruction begins. Its purpose is to gather information about students' prior knowledge, learning gaps, interests, and preferred learning styles. This data is vital in designing instruction that is differentiated, equitable, and effective. Unlike formative and summative assessments, diagnostic tools are not meant to measure achievement but to inform planning. They help teachers anticipate challenges, group students appropriately, and design targeted interventions.

Examples of Diagnostic Assessment:

Pre-Tests: Short quizzes or concept checks before a unit starts.

Concept Mapping: Students illustrate what they know about a topic.

Oral Interviews or Informal Discussions: Used to gauge understanding in a relaxed, low-pressure setting.

In Practice:

Before starting a poetry unit in an English classroom in Rajasthan, the teacher asked students to create mind maps on "What is a poem?" The results varied widely—some students thought poetry must rhyme, others associated it with nature. This helped the teacher decide to begin with non-rhyming contemporary poetry to broaden student perspectives.

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8.4.4 Ipsative Assessment: Growth Over Comparison

Ipsative assessment is perhaps the least discussed but one of the most meaningful form of assessment. It compares a learner's current performance with their own past performance, rather than with that of peers. This approach celebrates personal progress, emphasizing self-improvement, persistence, and goal setting. Ipsative assessments are ideal for building self-esteem, promoting self-awareness, and reinforcing a growth mindset. They help students reflect on their learning journeys and take ownership of their development.

Examples of Ipsative Assessment:

Skill Growth Journals: Students track their improvement in a specific area (e.g., vocabulary, handwriting, or time management).

Self-Assessment Checklists: Students regularly score their own progress on habits, attitudes, or skills.

Progress Graphs: Visual representation of improvement over time (e.g., reading speed, quiz scores, spelling errors).

Real-World Classroom Use:

In a government school in Uttar Pradesh, students maintained “My Learning Booklets,” tracking their weekly math progress. Each child compared a week's score with last week. Even students who were far behind others felt motivated because they saw themselves improving. This simple practice dramatically improved participation and reduced absenteeism in math classes.

8.4.5 Final Reflection on Types of Assessment

Each type of assessment offers unique insights and serves different goals. While formative and diagnostic assessments help in shaping instruction, summative assessments validate learning outcomes, and ipsative assessments fuel personal growth. A balanced blend of these methods ensures a comprehensive understanding of students, not just in what they know, but how they learn and evolve. When used thoughtfully and reflectively, assessment methods do not just measure learning—they nurture it.

8.4.6 Formative, Summative, and Diagnostic Assessments: A Comparative View

Understanding the comparative strengths and limitations of different types of assessments enables educators to make informed decisions in real-time classroom settings. While each form—formative, summative, and diagnostic—serves a distinct purpose, their strategic integration creates a well-rounded approach to learning evaluation. This section presents a side-by-side view that helps teachers analyse and choose the right method depending on timing, instructional goals, and learner needs.

Purpose and Focus of Each Assessment

Formative Assessment is used to support learning during the process. It's not concerned with final grades but with identifying how students are progressing and where they need support.

Summative Assessment measures overall achievement. It validates whether learning objectives have been met after instruction.

Diagnostic Assessment identifies where to begin. It uncovers prior knowledge, learning preferences, and potential hurdles before instruction starts.

This difference in purpose shapes how each method is designed, administered, and used for instructional planning.

Comparative Table

Table 8.1: Types of Assessment and Their Functions

Type	When Used	Purpose	Examples
Formative	During teaching	Improve teaching in real time	Quizzes, observations
Summative	End of a unit	Evaluate final learning	Tests, assignments
Diagnostic	Before teaching	Identify readiness or gaps	Pre-tests, oral checks
Ipsative	Anytime	Track personal progress	Portfolio comparisons



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Table 8.2: Strengths and Limitations of different types of Assessment

Assessment Type	Strengths	Limitations
Formative	Real-time adjustment; student engagement	Often informal and under-documented
Summative	Validates outcomes; standardized	Too late for support; can cause anxiety
Diagnostic	Helps plan; identifies misconceptions early	Time-consuming; needs careful design

Real Classroom Use Cases

Formative Example: In a middle school social studies class in Tamil Nadu, students used interactive maps to trace trade routes. The teacher paused periodically and asked them to discuss findings in pairs. When confusion about directions surfaced, she reintroduced cardinal concepts using a short video and physical compass demonstration.

Summative Example: In a CBSE-affiliated school in Noida, students completed a project comparing water usage across cultures. This interdisciplinary task counted towards their final marks and showcased understanding in geography, science, and ethics.

Diagnostic Example: A rural Jharkhand teacher gave her fifth-grade class a set of word problems in local dialects before starting a math unit. She discovered that while many students understood quantities intuitively, they lacked vocabulary for formal mathematical terms. She began instruction with storytelling and visual representation to bridge the gap.

8.4.7 Integrating Multiple Assessments for Stronger Pedagogy

Modern pedagogy encourages the triangulation of assessment types. Rather than treating each assessment as a standalone event, teachers can layer them. A concept may begin with a diagnostic pre-check, continue with formative adjustments, and conclude with a summative evaluation. Such integration creates a full cycle of learning: identifying readiness, supporting growth, and celebrating achievement.

Additionally, involving students in understanding this process fosters transparency and motivation. When students realize that assessment is not only about marks but also about understanding themselves as learners, they

participate more openly.

Comparing formative, summative, and diagnostic assessments is not about ranking them, but about recognizing when and how each best supports learning. Teachers who skilfully navigate between these types can scaffold instruction more effectively, address diverse needs, and promote a learning environment that is both empathetic and efficient.

8.6 ASSESSMENT:WHO, HOW AND WHEN

Teachers evaluate their students based on the cognitive, affective, and psychomotor domains that have been developed in them by the different teaching and learning scenarios and experiences that they have imparted throughout the teaching learning process. Children's assessments ought to be in line with the curriculum's objectives. If not aligned, children's performance will not accurately reflect their true learning from the curriculum. As can be cited with an illustration, if a teacher taught the topic 'verb' in a class, it would be unfair to expect children will develop competency in the application of adverbs by assessing them by asking questions, related to "Use of adverbs in the following sentences?" Another example can be the curriculum of a third-class English textbook includes topics like noun, verb, articles and prepositions, in a student the competencies related to these topics will be developed, it will be unfair on the part of the English teacher that while preparing the assessment sheet for the same the teacher will not include any questions from these topics to assess their learning. The assessment process must be thorough, focusing not only on knowledge and skills but also on values, morals, and attitudes learned. In conclusion, assessing children on skills not covered in the curriculum is unfair.

The teacher who is involved directly or indirectly with the children during the teaching and learning process should assess the progress. The teacher observes closely, knows each child's development, and plans the next cycle of activities. Therefore, she ought to be the one evaluating the kids in the group.

The incorporation of assessment in the process of teaching and learning starts immediately after the teacher enters the classroom to instruct a topic. For example, before introducing a topic, a teacher tries to know the previous knowledge of the students by asking some questions, by reciting any poem, or by telling a story, this integration aids the instructor to know what they already know about the topic and which teaching strategies/techniques should be further employed by them in the learning process, to enhance their learning. So, the assessment

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is not only helpful for the students to know their act, but additionally for the teachers in assessing them, as the teachers can make changes in the teaching learning process, learning experiences, as well as in the curriculum design, by the feedback received from the students. So, the assessment scope is very wide as it's an ongoing procedure that is associated with the teaching and learning process and cannot be restricted to a single task completed after the year. So, it can be concluded that a teacher must integrate assessment within the process of teaching and learning, so that the outcomes of the children's evaluation are fed into the teaching experiences, and accordingly, the teacher incorporates changes in the teaching process.

8.6 ASSESSMENT CYCLE

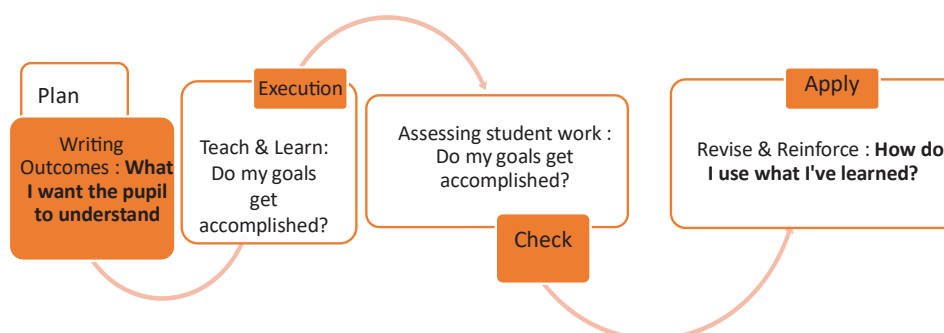


Fig.8.1: Assessment cycle

8.6.1 What I want the pupil to understand?

At this stage, the assessment data focuses on identifying learning outcomes for students and writing them in behavioural terms. The assessment must be aligned with the learning outcomes for its successful completion. Every institution has well-defined learning outcomes; these learning outcomes must be integrated at the program level. Conversely, the program learning outcomes must align with the course outcomes, which in turn must align with institutional outcomes. Well-defined learning objectives for students are essential for efficient planning and integration. Additionally, outcome statements need to target different cognitive skill levels and be quantifiable.

What are some effective teaching strategies?

At this stage, the assessment data focuses on what is to be taught to the students

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and what they have learned from the particular concept. However, the “DO” stage of the assessment cycle begins with instructors asking the question, “How do I teach effectively?”. This stage works as a bridge between the planning and checking stages.

The teachers plan their learning activities in such a way that the program outcomes at the course level can be attained by facilitating learning among the students as per the planning stage. The range of possible learning activities, projects, papers, performances, presentations, and exams are the most familiar direct measurement of student learning used at the course level. Learning experiences must be planned to stimulate learning among the students and to provide evaluation data for the subsequent Check stage evaluation.

The second stage also includes the development of assessment tools. The assessment of the Program is based not only on information collected in specific courses but also on information from other sources, like alumni surveys and assessment of the courses, but also from direct measures like standardised tests.

8.6.2 Are My Goals being Accomplished?

The previous stage concludes with students “doing” activities designed to help them achieve learning objectives developed at the “planning” stage. Effectively designed activities generate assessment data that is “checked” at this stage of the assessment cycle. The assessment should occur at both levels, that is, at the course and the program levels. The teacher assesses the activities of the students from time to time to know whether these activities help in the fulfilment of course requirements or not. The goal of checking is to ascertain how well students are meeting each goal. As a result, a course grade or other global indicator of student achievement is unlikely to yield adequate assessment information. Student performance on individual outcomes must be reported as precisely as possible for course and program evaluation to be effective.

8.6.3 How do I use what I’ve Learned?

Teachers are constantly working on the assessment results. If learning experiences fail to achieve course outcomes, the teacher makes changes in the planning. The teacher again replanned the lesson plan, as per the responses received from the students. This process of planning, replanning continues till all the learning outcomes are achieved.

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When the above process is followed within an individual course, the assessment cycle is complete and able to be repeated. Student learning instructions can be improved by the teachers at any stage of the process, but based on assessment data, the minimum requirements of assessment are being met, and adaptations can be made to improve the learning of the students. At both the course and program levels, the results of “checking” identify “actions” that will form the basis for subsequent planning.” Action, thus allows the Plan-Do-Check-Act cycle to continue.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 8.2**

1. Which of the following statements regarding recommendations made by National Education Policy 2020 is not correct?
 - a) NEP 2020 proposes that a variety of methods and strategies be used for assessment
 - b) NEP 2020 proposes a shift from formative to summative assessment
 - c) NEP 2020 proposes that apart from assessment by teachers other ways such as self-assessment and peer-assessment should be encouraged
 - d) NEP 2020 proposes to focus on regular formative assessment for learning
2. A feature of formative assessment is
 - a) To rank student at the end of term
 - b) To provide regular feedback for improvement
 - c) To conduct surprise test only
 - d) To determine eligibility for higher education
3. Which of the following best describes a summative test?
 - a) Evaluation conducted after instruction to judge students learning
 - b) An ongoing process to guide learning and provide feedback
 - c) Assessment given during the teaching process to improve students' performance

- d) Used primarily for diagnosing students learning needs before instructions

Answer: 1 - b; 2 - b; 3 - a

8.7 CATEGORIZATION OF ASSESSMENT

Assessment can be categorized based on the basis of the following criteria

- Test constructor – Standardised vs Teacher made
- Responses – Oral vs written vs Drawing
- Test administration – Individual vs. Group
- Quantification of Responses – Objective vs Subjective
- Result interpretation – Norm reference vs Criterion Reference

Response Type: As a response type, the evaluation test can be grouped as a performance, written, or oral test. An oral test is one where the test-taker provides their answers orally; a written test requires written responses, and, in a performance test, the test-taker produces a response or a product that showcases the knowledge and abilities of the students.

Quantification in Responses: As to simplicity in quantifying response, a test that is objective is one that uses paper and pencil and allows for the comparison and quantification of students' responses to produce a score. This is because it calls for a convergent and specific response. However, subjective tests, like essay tests, are paper-and-pencil assessments that are difficult to quantify because students are allowed to freely write their responses to questions.

Administration: Regarding how they are administered, tests can be administered individually or in groups. An individual test is an examination given to a single student at a time, whereas a group test is given to a group of students.

Test constructor type: Tests could be categorised as standardised and teacher-made or unstandardised. A standardised test is a test prepared by a subject expert, recognized national or international institutions following rigorous psychometric procedures. This type of test undergoes multiple rounds of validation to ensure reliability, objectivity, and fairness. Their structure, content, scoring, and interpretation guidelines are uniform and fixed, allowing comparisons across learners, regions, or time periods. Such tools are especially



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useful for large-scale assessments or for benchmarking learner performance against defined standards.

Examples of standardized tools include the Stanford Achievement Test used globally for academic benchmarking, and Raven's Progressive Matrices, a non-verbal test designed to assess general intelligence. In India, assessments like CBSE Class X and XII board exams, based on the National Curriculum Framework (NCF), and the NIPUN Bharat FLN tools are used for evaluating literacy and numeracy in primary grades. While these tools provide robust data for policy-level decisions, they may sometimes lack sensitivity to local contexts, individual learner needs, or inclusive pedagogy.

On the other hand, teacher-made tests are crafted by individual teachers or teaching teams specifically for their own classrooms. These tools are customized to reflect the learners' current level, curricular focus, and classroom realities. They are typically used for day-to-day assessment, especially formative and diagnostic assessment. Examples include chapter-end worksheets designed to check comprehension, oral questioning during class discussions, peer assessment rubrics created for group projects, and pre-test quizzes administered to gauge prior knowledge. For instance, a Class 4 teacher might design a worksheet on fractions that includes pictorial representations. After the activity, she reviews the errors and re-teaches the concept the following day. While teacher-made tools are flexible and responsive, their quality and effectiveness depend on the teacher's expertise and experience in assessment design.

Result Interpretation: Results can either be norm-referenced or criterion-referenced. A norm-referenced test is an assessment that compares a student's performance to that of a group of students taking the same test. However, a criterion-referenced test is an assessment that compares a student's performance to a pre-established level of performance.

8.8 POLICY CONTEXT: NEP 2020

The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 places a strong emphasis on transforming the assessment landscape in India. It envisions a shift from high-stakes examinations and rote learning to formative, diagnostic, and adaptive assessments that are rooted in real-world competencies. It articulates a paradigm shift promoting holistic, inclusive, and competency-based assessments aligned with 21st-century skills and learner diversity.

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NEP 2020 (Section 4.34) states, that “Report cards will be redesigned to include self-assessment, peer assessment, and teacher assessment; progress in cognitive, affective, and psychomotor domains will be included in the report.”

This clearly indicates the need for documented, continuous, and qualitative forms of assessment—an approach that goes beyond numerical grading. Thus, the Section 4.34 advocates for the creation of Holistic Progress Cards (HPC) that cover cognitive, affective, and psychomotor domains. The section 4.35 of the policy proposes the creation of PARAKH – a national assessment centre to standardize and reform school assessments. The emphasis on competency-based learning outcomes, developed in partnership with NCERT, as essential metrics for evaluating student learning. These directives reflect a clear move toward assessment for learning rather than assessment of learning.

The Holistic Progress Card (HPC) framework, introduced by NCERT and supported by the Ministry of Education, further reinforces this. As per the NCERT 2023 Guidelines:

- The HPC should capture multi-dimensional aspects of growth.
- Teachers are required to document evidence of the children’s achievements in academic, physical, emotional, and social domains.
- There should be space for narrative observations, samples of student work, and reflections.

Evolving Roles of Assessment Beyond Grades

Assessment has traditionally been perceived as a method of ranking students based on marks or grades, usually derived from written exams. However, such a narrow approach fails to recognize the diversity in learners’ abilities, efforts, and intelligences. With the evolution of educational philosophies, technological tools, and policy mandates—especially the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020—assessment has been redefined not as an endpoint but as an integral part of the learning process.

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This shift marks a movement from summative, memory-based assessment to formative, developmental, and competency-based assessment aimed at nurturing the holistic development of every learner.

Table 8.3: Key Shifts in Assessment Philosophy

Conventional Assessment	Evolved Assessment (Post-NEP)
Focus on memory and content recall	Focus on application, creativity, values, and critical thinking
One-time summative exams	Continuous and comprehensive assessments
Marksheets and grades	360° feedback with descriptive indicators
Teacher-centric evaluation	Multi-source feedback: self, peers, parents, and teachers
Annual report cards	Dynamic learning portfolios and progress cards
Quantitative evaluation	Combination of qualitative and quantitative insights

Understanding the Shift Through Classroom Examples

In the traditional model, a student scoring 90% in mathematics is assumed to have high competence. However, such scores may not reveal their conceptual understanding, problem-solving approach, or real-world application skills. However, in the evolved model, assessment includes performance tasks, reasoning-based problems, and observations of collaboration during group work. For instance, a student who contributes creative solutions in a science exhibition or shows leadership in a class project is now recognized through teacher narratives, peer reflections, and project rubrics—none of which are captured by conventional exams.

In subjects like Visual Arts or Physical Education, the traditional approach often sidelined them as non-academic. Today, students are assessed through portfolios, participation records, skill observation rubrics, and self-reflection journals, providing a more holistic representation of their growth.

8.9 GLOBAL BEST PRACTICES IN ASSESSMENT

Globally, several education systems have already embraced this broader vision of assessment:

1. Finland:
 - Uses descriptive assessment throughout schooling.

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- Emphasizes teacher autonomy in observation-based evaluations.
 - Removes high-stakes grading until later school years.
2. Singapore:
- Employs e-portfolios and performance-based assessments.
 - Includes student reflections and self-assessment in progress reports.
 - Uses non-academic indicators like resilience, curiosity, and collaboration.
3. OECD's Learning Compass 2030:
- Promotes student agency and lifelong learning.
 - Encourages documentation of transversal competencies like global citizenship, well-being, and empathy.
 - Values qualitative data and longitudinal records over standard grades.
 - India's NEP-aligned transformation reflects the intent to join global movements focusing on student well-being, personalized growth, and holistic development.

8.9.1 Indian Initiatives Supporting the Shift

1. NCERT's Guidelines for Holistic Progress Card (2023)
- Introduces templates for tracking academic, social, emotional, and physical development.
 - Recommends use of:
 - Anecdotal records from teachers
 - Peer and self-evaluation
 - Co-scholastic skills assessment
 - Teacher observations and comments
2. CBSE's Competency-Based Assessment Framework (from 2021 onwards)
- Integrates real-life scenarios, application-based questions, and analytical tasks into assessments.
 - Encourages use of performance rubrics, reflection sheets, and evidence-

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based evaluation tools.

- Promotes professional development of teachers for authentic assessment design. Innovative Practices from Indian States

3. Delhi's Happiness Curriculum Evaluations:

- Teachers maintain records of students' emotional well-being, class participation, and interpersonal skills.
- Assessment includes observation checklists, journals, and qualitative feedback during weekly happiness classes.

4. Karnataka's Use of Portfolios During Pandemic:

In response to school closures many schools, maintained student portfolios to track home-based learning.

Students documented activities, reflections, and creative projects, which teachers assessed qualitatively.

Parents were engaged as partners in the documentation process, encouraging home-school collaboration.

Significance of the Evolved forms of assessment

- Learning becomes more personalized.
- Children from diverse backgrounds receive fairer recognition.
- Teachers become facilitators and mentors, not just evaluators.
- The system prioritizes development over competition, creating an environment where students are motivated to improve rather than fear failure.



8.10 LET US SUM UP

As we have discovered thus far, assessment is a crucial part of the teaching process. The methodical process of collecting data on children through a range of techniques, documenting this data, considering it, and applying it to enhance and better understand their learning and development is known as assessment. Assessment of learning and assessment for learning are the two main approaches

to assessment. Instructors can assess their students using several methods, such as observing them in various contexts. Additionally, the ideas of standardised and non-standardised assessment were discussed.



8.11 END EXERCISES

1. Elaborate upon the cycle of assessment with the help of a diagram.
2. How would you differentiate between the concept of ‘assessment for learning’ and ‘assessment of learning’. Explain with examples from your school teaching.
3. Why do you think that teacher-made tests are important in classrooms at the primary level? Explain with examples.
4. Explain the difference between teacher-made tests and standardised tests.
5. Why is it important for a teacher to assess the learner from time to time?
6. Elaborate upon any three characteristics of assessment.

8.12 REFERENCES

Ministry of Human Resource Development. (2020). National Education Policy. Government of India.

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